

"If we exert ourselves with determination, no obstacle, however formidable, can stop our progress."

BENGAL TIGER

Modern India's two architects Jawaharlal Nehru and Vallabhbhai Patel relied on him, but he never turned his views into polemics and always submitted to the majority opinion

■ By Nitish Sengupta

Bidhan Chandra Roy was one of the foremost national leaders of the 20th century India. A legendary physician, a distinguished Congress leader, an educationist and a philanthropist, Roy became the chief minister of West Bengal and transformed it from a problem state into a prosperous one. He was a leader whose advice Jawaharlal Nehru and Vallabhbhai Patel always relied upon. From the time he defeated the formidable Surendranath Bannerjea in an election in the early 1920s, there was no looking back as he successfully occupied important positions. He was mayor of Calcutta, vice-chancellor of Calcutta University and member of the Congress Working Committee. In

B.C. Roy

Physician, politician 1882-1962

1948, he declined the position of governor of Uttar Pradesh for which he was approved by King George VI, because he wanted to be in active politics. Shortly thereafter, he assumed the stewardship of West Bengal.

How refreshingly free he was from ideological controversies is exemplified by the fact that in 1957,

when Nehru and P. C. Mahalanobis were all set to introduce Soviet style planning with emphasis on creating basic and heavy industries and financing them by curtailing consumption, Roy chose to cross swords with Mahalanobis with his sophisticated econometric models and recommended a policy where primary emphasis was to be given initially to agriculture. Industrial development was to take place from out of the surplus generated by agriculture. He was totally opposed to import control or foreign exchange control. But he did not turn his views into polemics and submitted to the majority opinion when he was overruled by Nehru and Mahalanobis.

Two other aspects which are almost forgotten are Roy's role as an industrialist and as a journalist. As an industrialist he promoted the Shillong Hydro-Electricity Corporation and Airways India. As a journalist he took the responsibility of some journals started by Chittaranjan Das, namely, *Forward*, *Bangabasi* and *Atmasakti*. He edited another journal called *Liberty* and was the founding chairman of the United Press of India.

A true karmayogi, he died working almost till the last hour of his life on July 1, 1962, which also happened to be his birthday.

The author is a former Lok Sabha MP



Q: How many admission requests did he send to the dean at St. Bartholomew in England before he was finally accepted?

A: 29

Q: How is his birthday, July 1, celebrated in India?

A: As Doctor's Day

Q: Which was his favourite song? He sang it even on the day of his death.

A: The *Brahmo Geet*